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their share of downturns since 2015, when both India and Nepal laid claim to the disputed land area of Kalapani, Lipulekh and Limpiyadhura in western Nepal. In 2020, Nepal updated its map by incorporating the strategically important areas, causing New Delhi to term it as a "unilateral act" and an "artificial enlargement". The controversy flared up again in early May, when Kathmandu announced the printing of a new Rs 100 currency note with a map that showed the three areas.

Over this uncomfortable situation hovers India's most implacable foe, China, which has been steadily expanding its strategic and economic footprint in Nepal. The fallout from the recruitment freeze of Nepali Gorkhas raises another dangerous possibility—their recruitment into the People's Liberation Army (PLA) of China. The revelation that around 15,000 Nepali youths are fighting in the Russian army on the battlefields of Ukraine has rung alarm bells in the Indian security establishment. Though there is no immediate concern, the prospect of Gorkhas fighting for the Chinese against India on the Himalayan frontiers is not a pretty one. "It has been close to five years since we have recruited a Nepali Gurkha," says an officer of the Indian army. "It seems that the future of the Gorkha Brigade and its 38 battalions is bleak, considering the adamant position of both nations."

A SYMBIOTIC RELATIONSHIP

Ever since British commander Sir David Ochterlony recognised the superior fighting qualities of Gorkha soldiers during the Anglo-Nepal war (1814-1816) and raised the first Gorkha regiment in 1815, they have been part of the Indian army. Post-independence, the Gorkha regiments have given the army several chiefs, including the legendary Field Marshal Sam Manekshaw and, more recently, Gen. Dalbir Singh Suhag, Gen. Bipin Rawat and the present Chief of Defence Staff, Gen. Anil Chauhan. Also the most decorated Indian General, the late Lt Gen. Zorawar Chand (Zoru) Bakshi.

OTHER THAN 32,000 SERVING SOLDIERS, NEPAL HAS AROUND 122,000 GORKHA PENSIONERS WHO SERVED IN INDIA. AS THEY ARE OUR EYES AND EARS THERE, A DROP IN NUMBERS MEANS A DROP IN INDIA'S SOFT-POWER REACH

The decades-long arrangement of Gorkhas serving in the Indian army has been beneficial to both sides. Nepal's weak economy means that career opportunities for its youth have been extremely limited. Service in the Indian army has been lucrative, as the pay is 2.5x of what the Nepalese army pays, while the pension provides economic security. Retired Nepali Gorkhas also have the option to settle down in India. As of April 2024, Nepal has around 122,000 pensioners who served in India. The Indian government, through various branches of the Defence Wing, provides social and medical benefits for them and their dependants on par with their Indian counterparts. The remittances that serving Gorkhas send home have given Nepal an economic cushion during difficult times. Their contribution to Nepal's GDP is crucial too, as the salaries and pensions from India are greater than Nepal's defence budget.

Nepal's objections to the Agnipath scheme, therefore, are based on hard economic facts. The 75 per cent of recruits who return would have no pension rights and have to seek employment elsewhere. Also, a large number of youths with military training but without jobs can pose a security threat.

Brig. Gen. Prem Basnayat (retd), a former high-ranking officer from the Nepali army, feels the Agnipath recruitment scheme is against the basic norms of soldering. "It is high time to amend or reframe the Tripartite Agreement so that Nepalese youths can join the Indian army under Agnipath with terms and conditions," he tells INDIA